

The Shed's Second Economy

Peer-to-peer swaps a tool library's front-desk ledger never captures

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Background

Neighbourhood tool libraries track circulation through a front-desk sign-out ledger, the one indicator most report to their funding co-op as a return rate. Little is known about how much borrowing the ledger never sees at all.

Aims

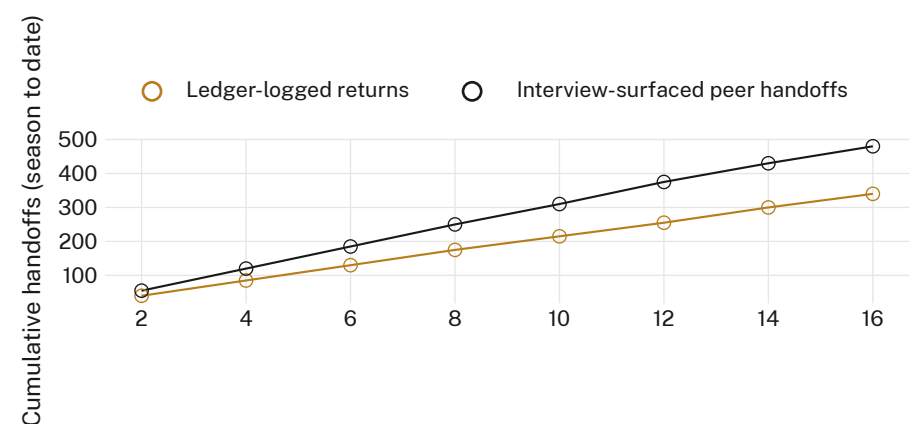
- Estimate the share of a tool library's true circulation that never touches the front-desk ledger
- Catalogue the forms a peer-to-peer swap takes once two members arrange a handoff directly
- Test whether a shed's reported return-rate KPI tracks its actual circulation, or only its own count

Methods

- n = 3 neighbourhood tool libraries · exit interviews with 96 borrowers over one season
- self-reported peer handoffs coded into a four-category swap taxonomy
- each site's ledger return-rate KPI held as the comparison baseline throughout

Results

Exit interviews surfaced peer-to-peer handoffs equivalent to 41% of the season's logged returns across the three sites; the front-desk return-rate KPI held above 96% throughout, unmoved by handoffs it never recorded (Fig. 1).



Interview-surfaced peer handoffs outpaced the ledger's own logged returns every fortnight of the 16-week season, reaching 41% more cumulative handoffs by week 16 (three tool libraries, 96 borrowers).

Discussion & conclusions

A return-rate KPI can sit at ceiling while a fifth of a shed's real circulation happens entirely off its books — consistent with a pattern already seen where a bike-share scheme's own RFID return log tracked audited helmet counts only weakly ($r = 0.05$; Ref. 5). Whether the parallel economy relieves pressure on a shed's stock or just defers it to the next inventory count remains untested. Next: instrumenting a fourth site with return-window reminders to see whether nudging the ledger back into the loop changes borrower behaviour.

References

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We thank the volunteer stewards of the three participating tool libraries. Exit-interview responses de-identified before coding; no membership or warranty records retained beyond the season.

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